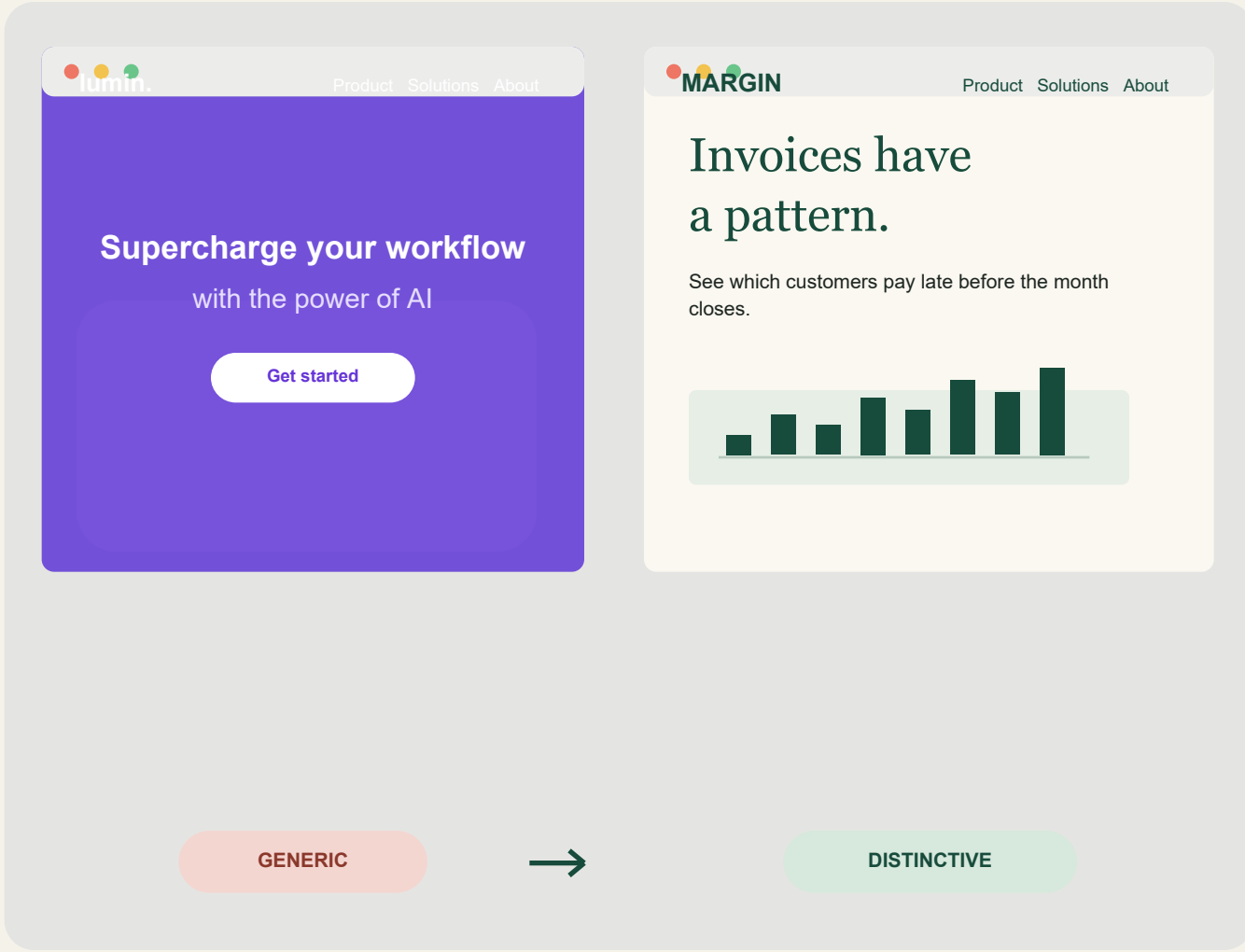
A VISUAL REFERENCE FOR CLAUDE

BEYOND THE AI WEBSITE TEMPLATE

Eight common defaults, eight stronger directions, and a practical audit to use before shipping.



REFERENCE GUIDE / 2026

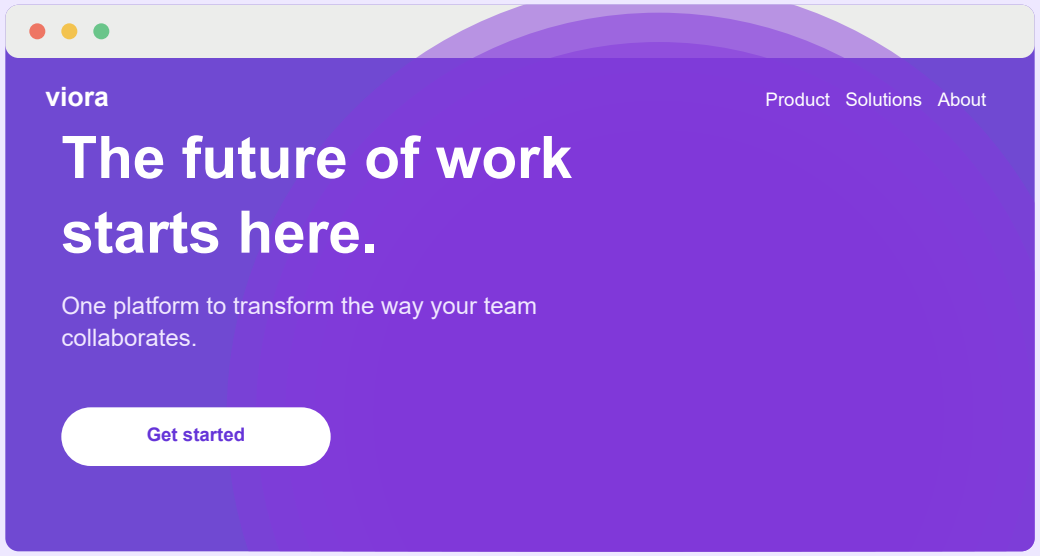
ORIGINAL ILLUSTRATIONS / NOT REAL WEBSITES

01 / COLOR

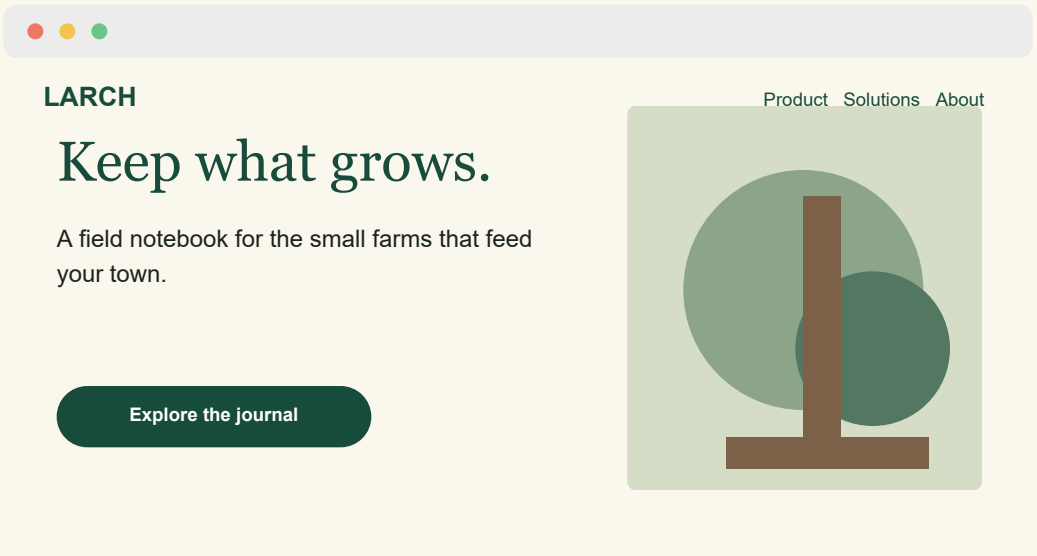
Purple gradient as a personality

A familiar palette is not an identity by itself.

GENERIC DEFAULT



STRONGER DIRECTION



WHY IT FAILS

The same purple haze fits almost any product. It signals a category without saying what the brand believes or does.

BETTER MOVE

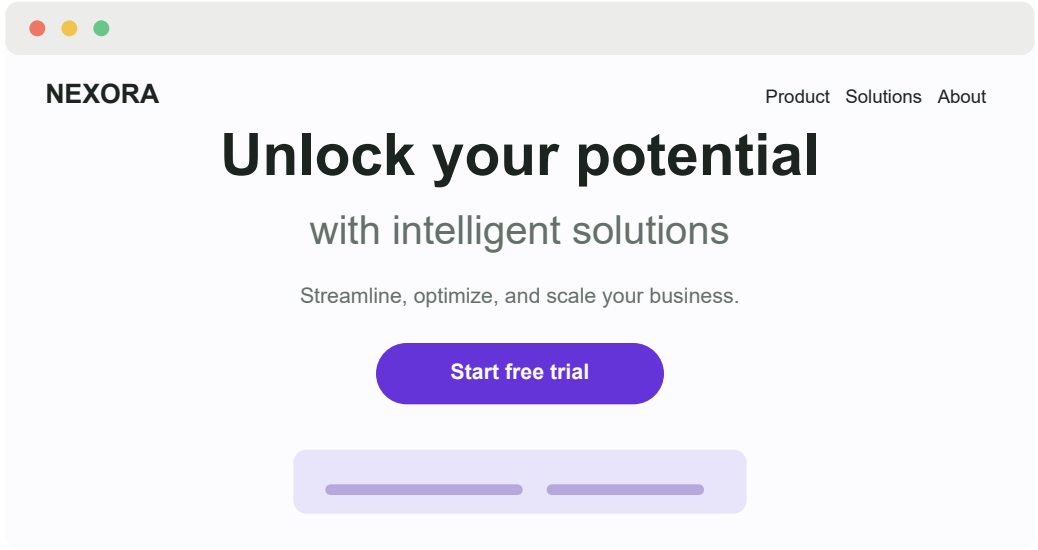
Choose colors from the subject, audience, and tone. Give the palette a role: paper, foliage, soil, and one clear action color.

02 / MESSAGE

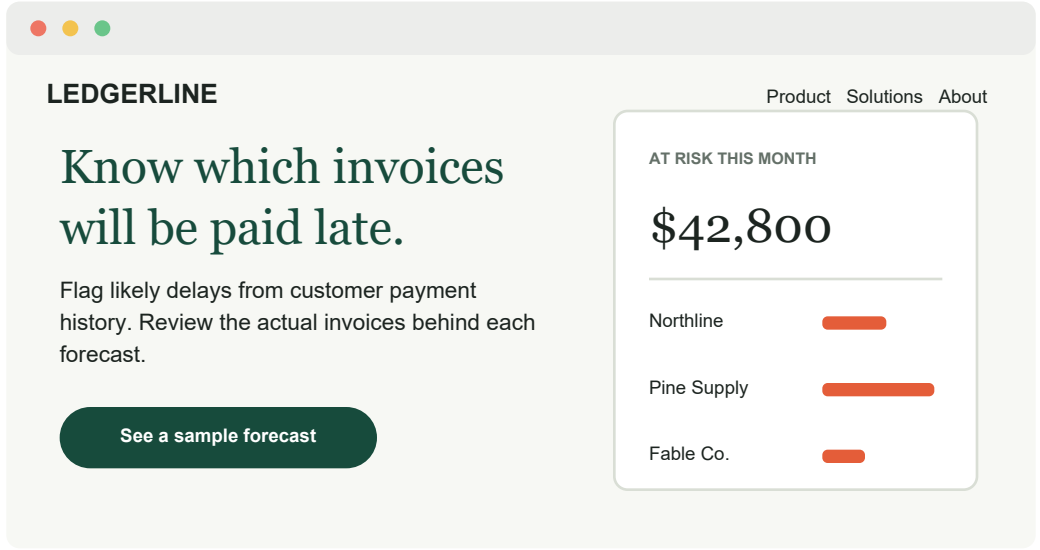
The interchangeable SaaS hero

If the product name can be swapped without changing the page, rewrite it.

GENERIC DEFAULT



STRONGER DIRECTION



WHY IT FAILS

Abstract promises make the visitor work to infer the product, user, and outcome. A decorative dashboard does not resolve the ambiguity.

BETTER MOVE

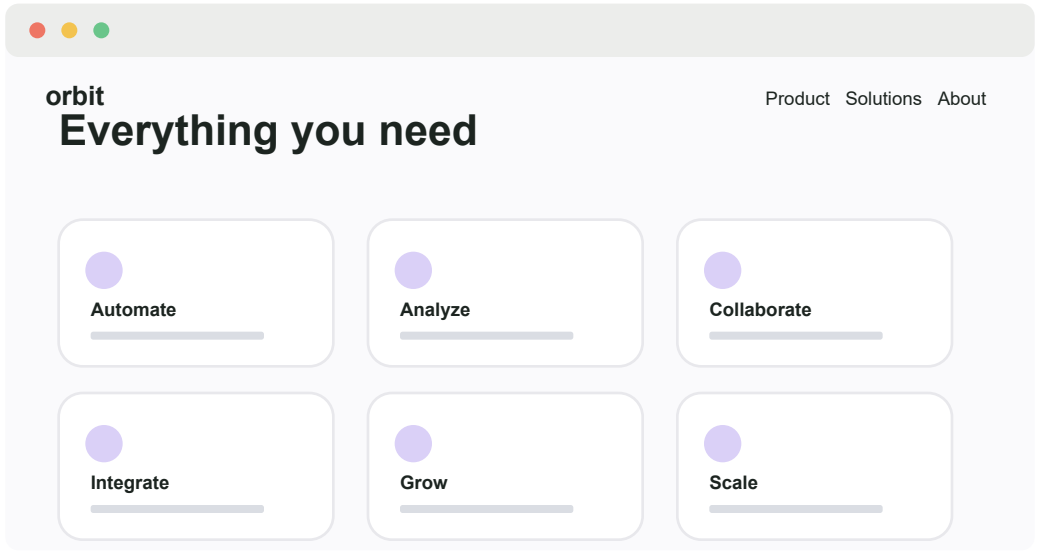
Name the user problem, the concrete result, and the evidence. Show a real task or representative interface beside the claim.

03 / LAYOUT

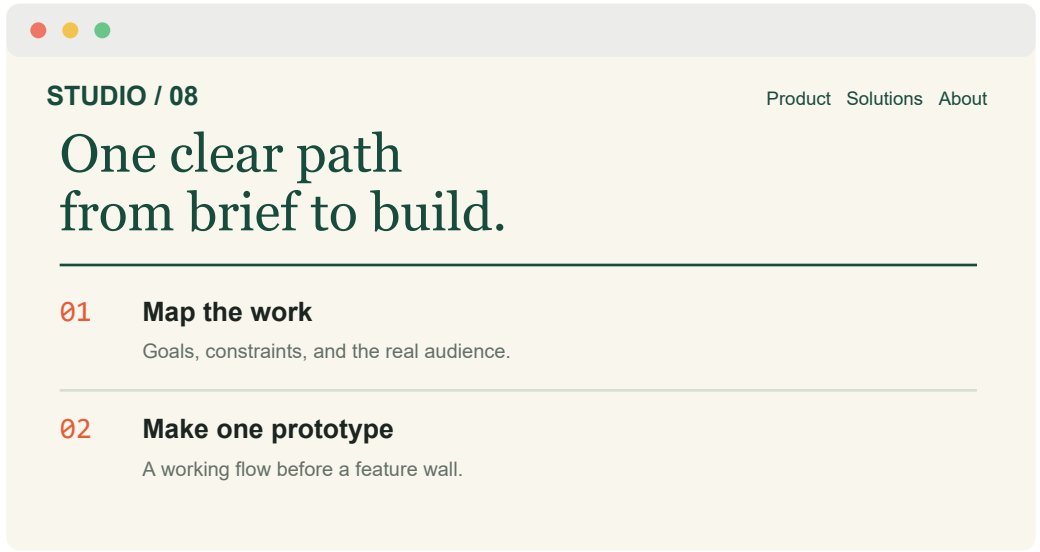
Cards for everything

Uniform containers flatten the story when content has different importance.

GENERIC DEFAULT



STRONGER DIRECTION



WHY IT FAILS

Six identical boxes give six ideas equal weight. Repeated icons, radii, and filler lines make the section feel assembled from components.

BETTER MOVE

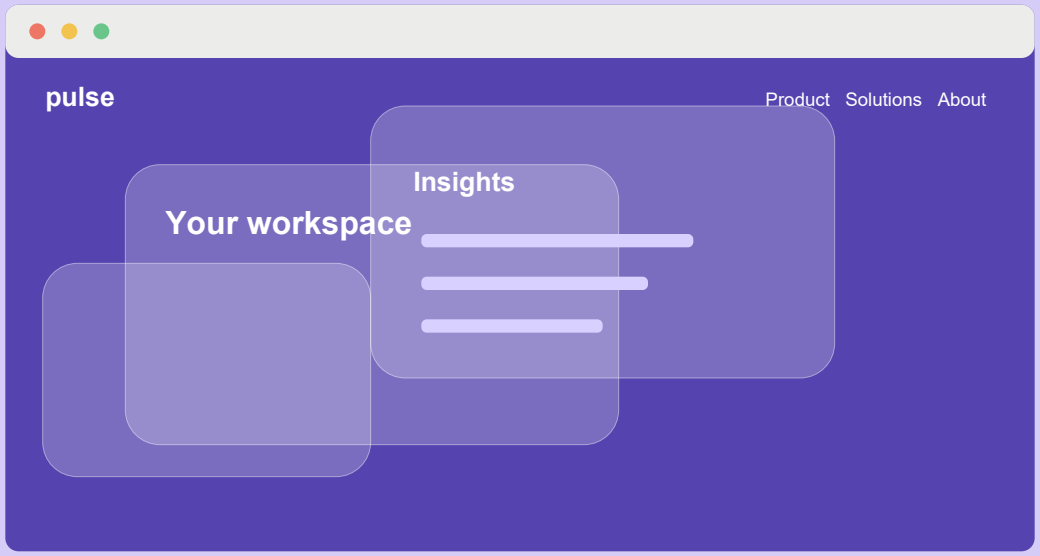
Match structure to meaning: one lead idea, an ordered process, a comparison table, or a plain list. Use cards when items are genuinely peers.

04 / SURFACE

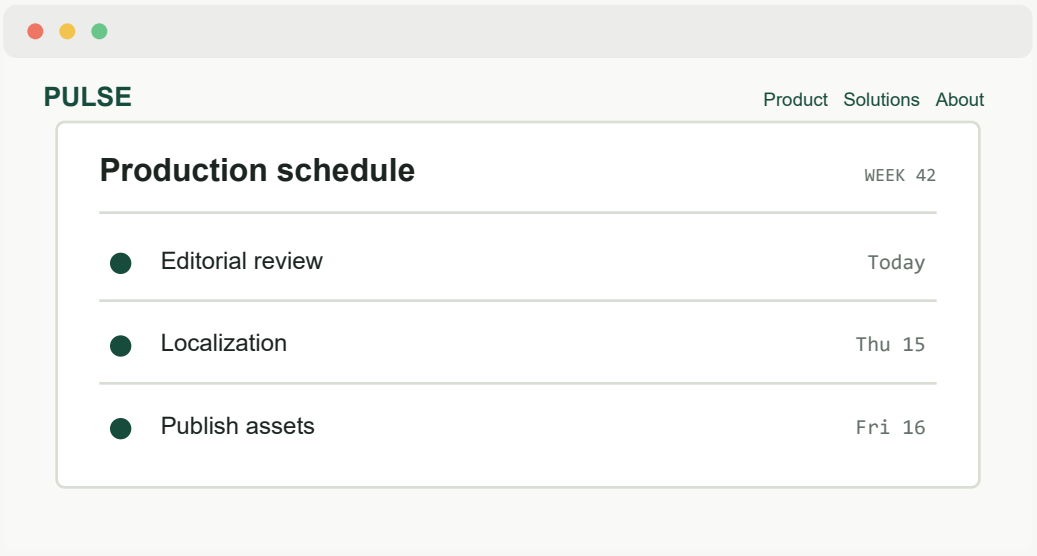
Glassmorphism without a reason

Translucency adds layers, but often hides the actual work.

GENERIC DEFAULT



STRONGER DIRECTION



WHY IT FAILS

Blur and transparency reduce text contrast, create ambiguous stacking, and use decoration to imply complexity.

BETTER MOVE

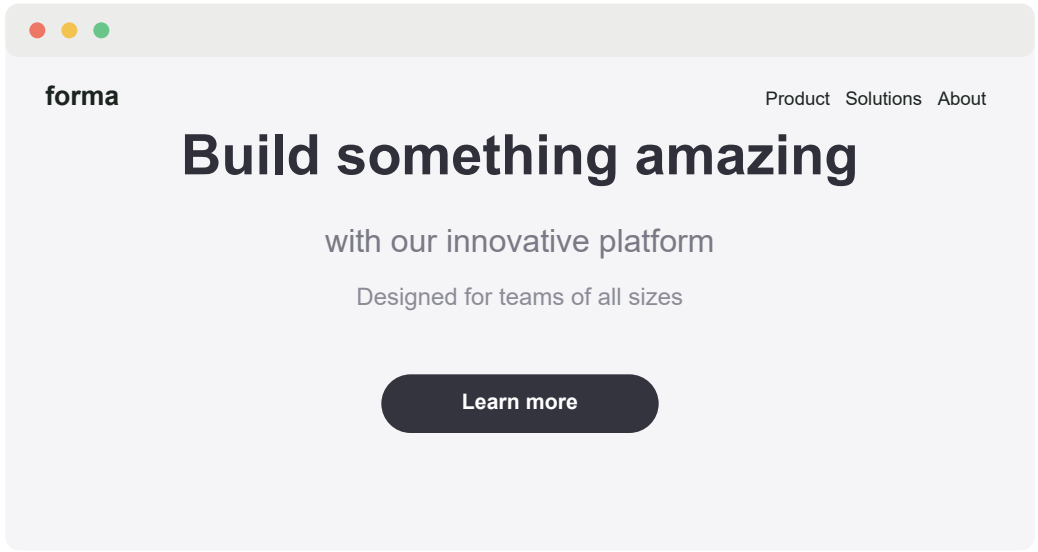
Use opaque surfaces, visible grouping, and a clear reading order. Add depth only if it explains overlap or focus.

05 / TYPOGRAPHY

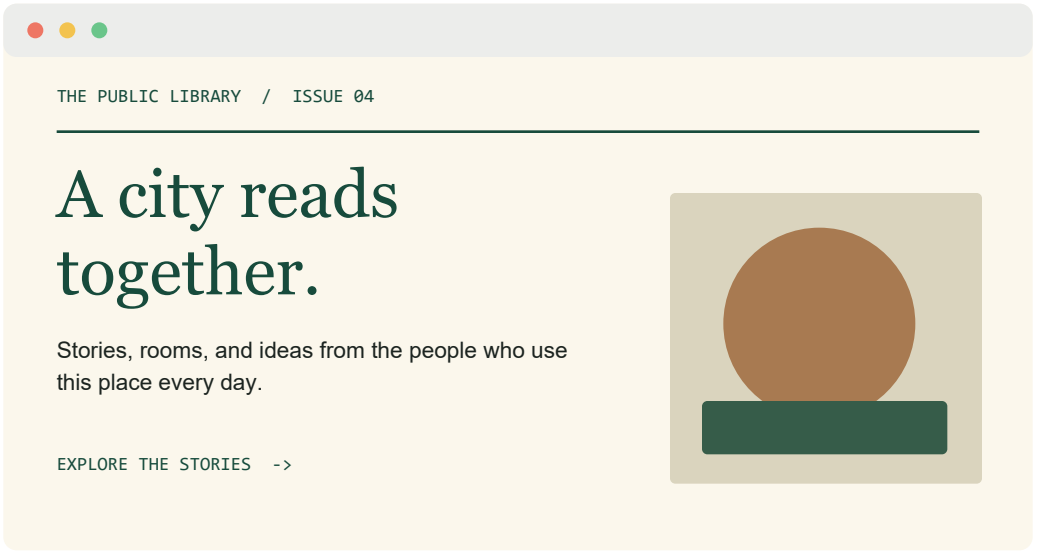
Bland typography, bland hierarchy

A font choice matters less than a deliberate type system.

GENERIC DEFAULT



STRONGER DIRECTION



WHY IT FAILS

The entire page speaks in one neutral voice: centered headline, similar line lengths, and predictable weights. There is no editorial rhythm.

BETTER MOVE

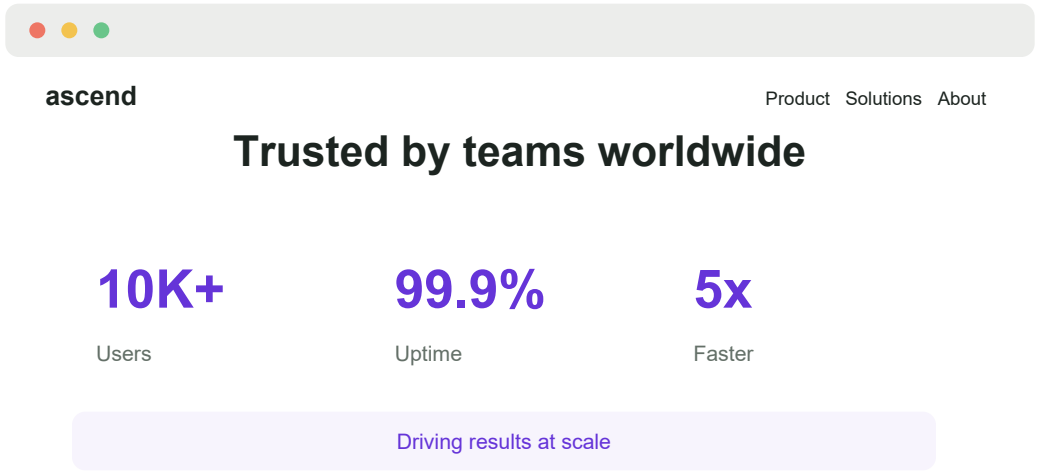
Define a display voice, a readable body voice, and a small utility style. Vary scale, alignment, and line length to guide attention.

06 / PROOF

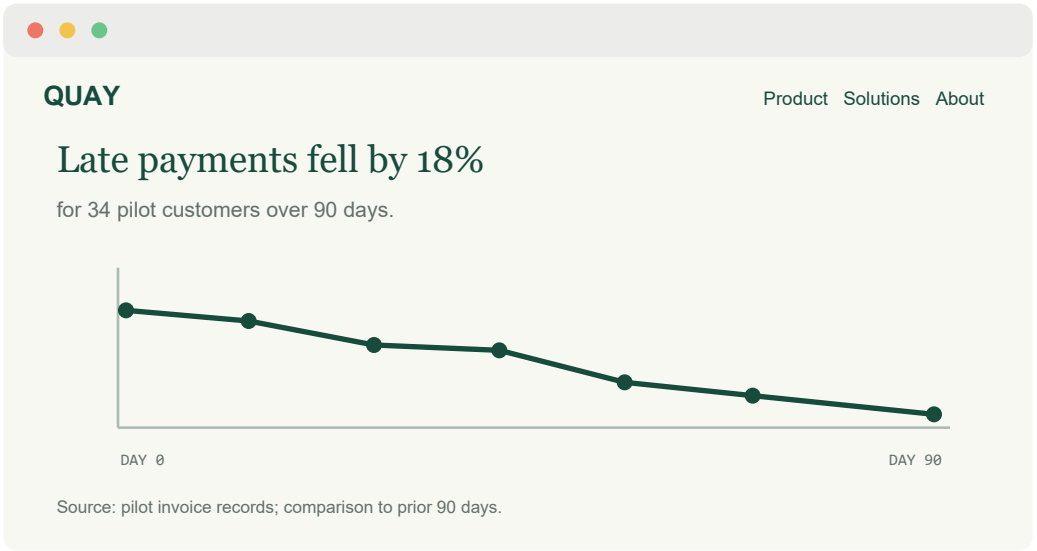
Meaningless metrics

Numbers are useful only when the reader can judge what they measure.

GENERIC DEFAULT



STRONGER DIRECTION



WHY IT FAILS

A large number with no unit, time frame, denominator, or source is decoration. The claim may be impossible to evaluate.

BETTER MOVE

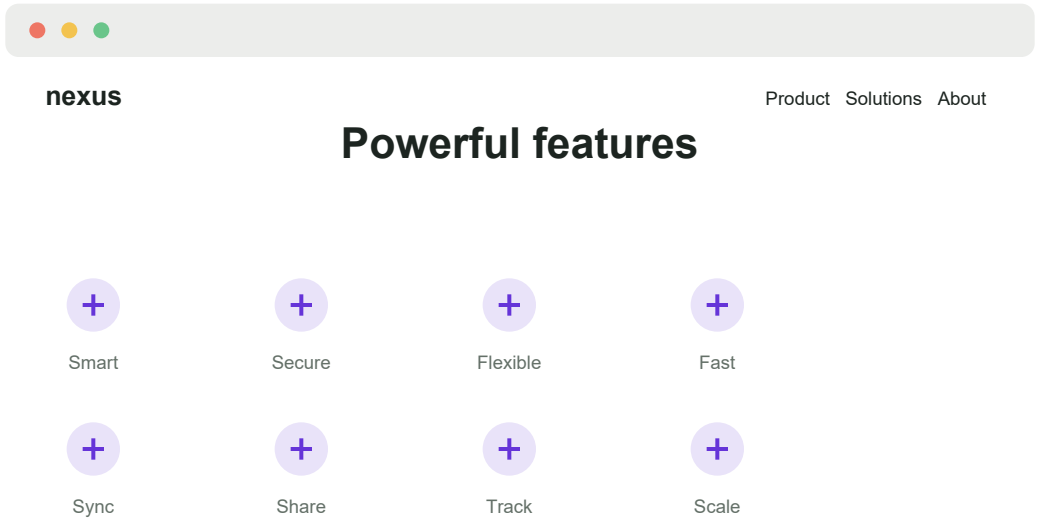
Use a metric tied to a user outcome. Label the measure, population, period, baseline, and source. If proof is weak, show the product instead.

07 / FEATURES

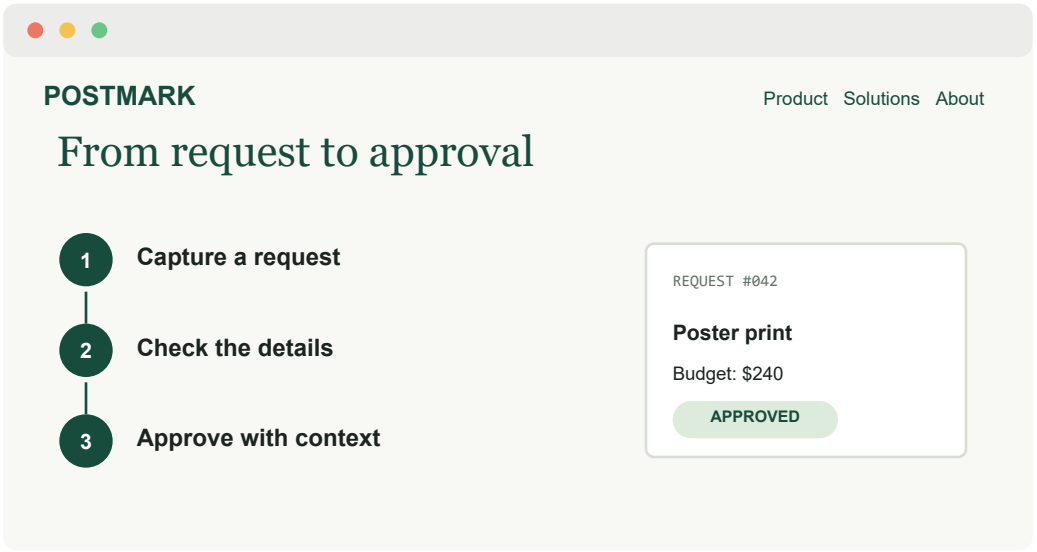
The endless icon grid

A catalog of capabilities rarely explains what someone can actually do.

GENERIC DEFAULT



STRONGER DIRECTION



WHY IT FAILS

Repeated symbols make unlike features feel interchangeable. Generic labels such as Smart and Fast say little about a workflow.

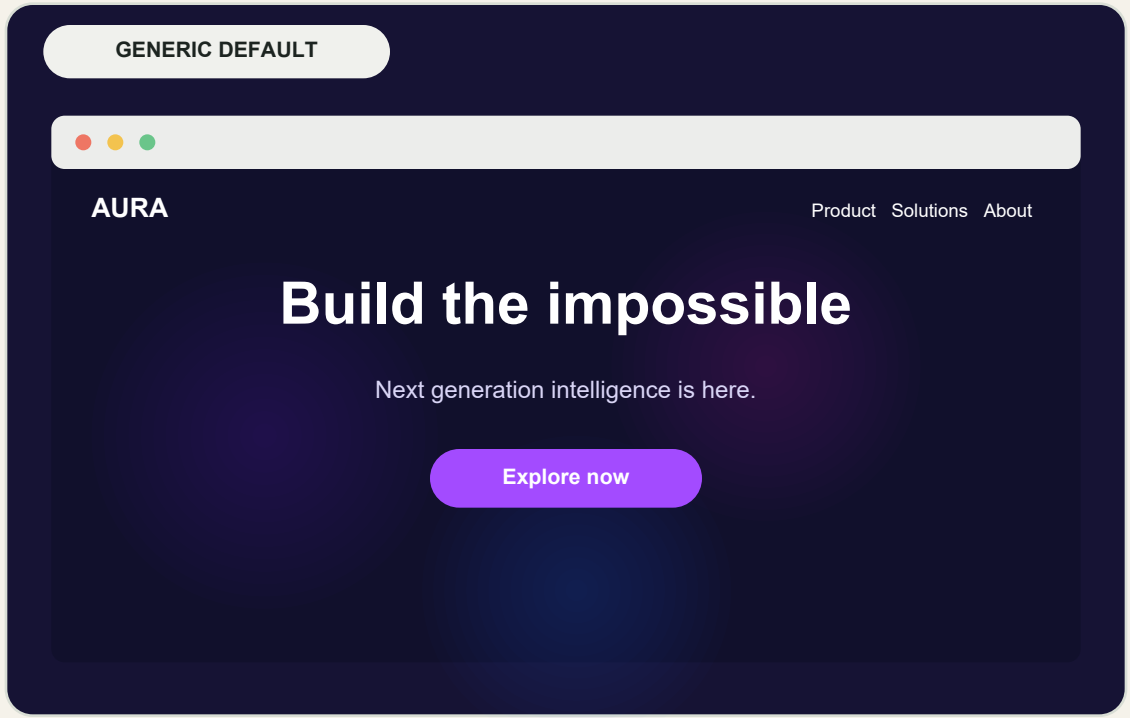
BETTER MOVE

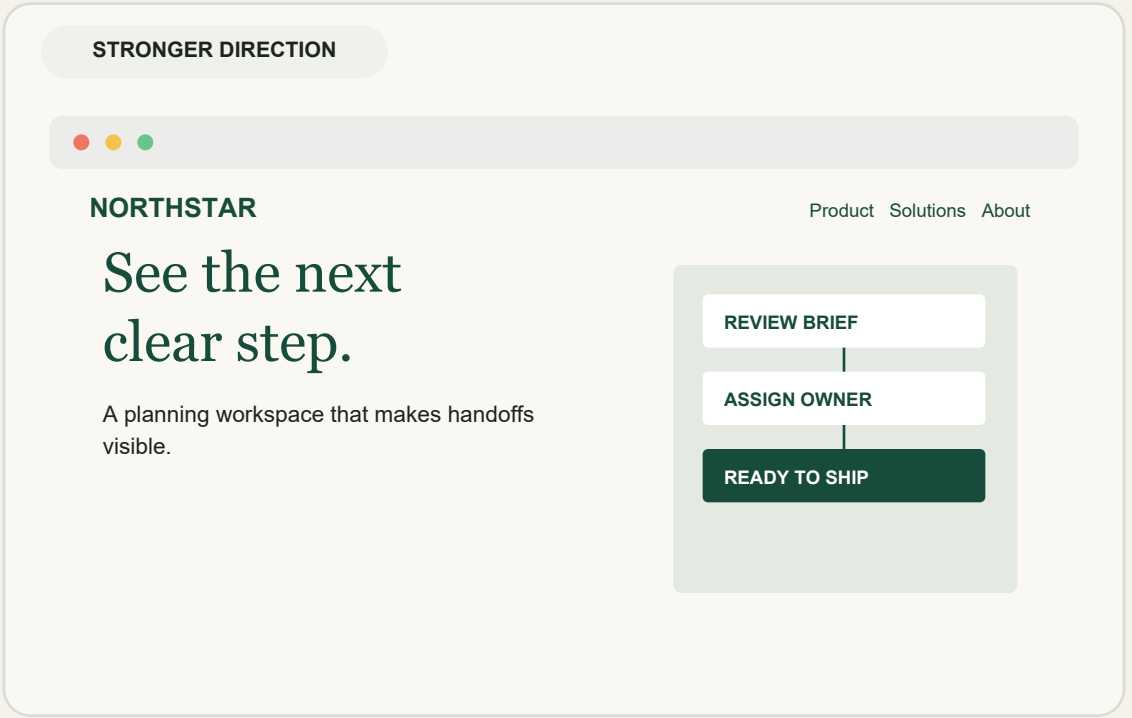
Group features around real tasks. Show sequence, decisions, and a representative screen. Let the interface carry the explanation.

08 / EFFECTS

Glow competing with content

Effects should create focus, not become the focus.





WHY IT FAILS

Multiple luminous spots compete with the heading and action. Brightness substitutes for hierarchy and can reduce readability.

BETTER MOVE

Reserve effects for a single meaningful focal point. Start with spacing, contrast, and useful content; add restrained light only if it clarifies emphasis.

BEFORE YOU SHIP

The anti-template audit

Run this on the full page, not just the hero. A recognizable pattern is a prompt to inspect, not an automatic ban.

01 MESSAGE

Can a visitor identify who it serves, what it does, and the next action in five seconds?

02 SPECIFICITY

Could this headline, image, or metric belong to a competitor? Replace what is interchangeable.

03 HIERARCHY

Is there one clear lead idea per section? Are secondary ideas visibly secondary?

04 STRUCTURE

Does each layout fit its content, or is every section a row of rounded cards?

05 PROOF

Do numbers include units, dates, context, and a source? Remove unsupported claims.

06 VISUAL IDENTITY

Can you explain the palette, type, imagery, and shape choices in terms of the brand?

07 EFFECTS

Do gradients, blur, glass, and glow serve content? Remove any effect that only fills space.

08 ACCESSIBILITY

Check text contrast, focus states, motion, responsive layout, and readable type sizes.

FINAL TEST **Remove the logo. Would this page still feel like the same brand?**

COPY INTO CLAUDE

A brief that demands decisions

Use this as a starting instruction, then add the real brand, audience, content, and constraints.

```
Design this website from the product, audience, and content outward.
Before coding, state: (1) the audience and their key task, (2) a distinct visual concept,
(3) the page hierarchy, and (4) why the typography, color, and imagery fit this brand.

Avoid default AI-site patterns: purple gradients, vague SaaS claims, uniform rounded
card grids, decorative glass, generic icons, invented metrics, and excessive glow.
Use any of these only when you can explain the specific purpose they serve.

Write concrete copy. Show representative product states or task-based examples.
Use varied section structures based on the information. Keep one clear action per view.
Check desktop and mobile layouts, text contrast, keyboard focus, and reduced motion.

Before delivery, audit the result against the eight checks in this guide. Identify the
three most generic decisions, revise them, and explain the final design tradeoffs.
```

Design references: NN/g on visual hierarchy and cards; W3C WCAG on text contrast.

nngroup.com/articles/principles-visual-design/ | nngroup.com/articles/cards-component/ | w3.org/WAI/WCAG21/Understanding/contrast-minimum